

RG06

Biodiversity Conservation: Parks, Sanctuaries, Reserves

Rajasthan Geography gives 11-15 questions every paper, and protected areas alone contribute 2-4 of them. Sanctuary-to-district matching was asked in 2016, 2021, 2023 and 2024; tiger reserve count and the newest reserve came in 2023 and 2024; Ramsar sites in 2016 and 2023. Format is match-the-following, NOT-correctly-matched and statement-based.

This is the biggest matching chapter in Rajasthan Geography. RPSC almost never asks you to explain conservation - it asks you which district a sanctuary is in, which animal it is famous for, and in which year a tiger reserve was notified. So the whole chapter is really four tables plus a species section, and it must be learnt cold.

Protected Areas of Rajasthan

National parks (5)

- Ranthambore - Sawai Madhopur
- Keoladeo Ghana - Bharatpur
- Sariska - Alwar
- Desert NP - Jaisalmer, Barmer
- Mukundra Hills - Kota belt

Tiger reserves (5 notified)

- Ranthambore 1973
- Sariska 1978
- Mukundra Hills 2013
- Ramgarh Vishdhari 2022
- Dholpur-Karauli 2023
- Kumbhalgarh - proposed 6th

Star sanctuaries

- Tal Chhapar - blackbuck
- Sitamata - flying squirrel
- National Chambal - gharial
- Kumbhalgarh - Indian wolf
- Mount Abu - evergreen patches

Conservation reserves

- Bisalpur, Tonk - first, 2008
- Jodbeed Gadhwala - vultures
- Jawai Bandh - leopard
- Sundha Mata - Jalore, Sirohi
- Sorsan - lesser florican

Ramsar sites (5)

- Keoladeo Ghana 1981
- Sambhar Lake 1990
- Khichan 2025
- Menar 2025
- Siliserh, Alwar 2025

Species projects

- Godawan - Project GIB 2013
- Chinkara - state animal
- Jhalana - first leopard reserve
- Sariska - first tiger relocation
- Khichan - demoiselle cranes

State symbols

- Bird - Godawan (1981)
- Animal wild - chinkara (1981)
- Animal domestic - camel (2014)
- Tree - khejri
- Flower - rohida

People and institutions

- Kailash Sankhala - Tiger Man
- Amrita Devi Bishnoi - Khejarli 1730
- Jaipur Zoo 1876
- Wildlife Week 2-8 October

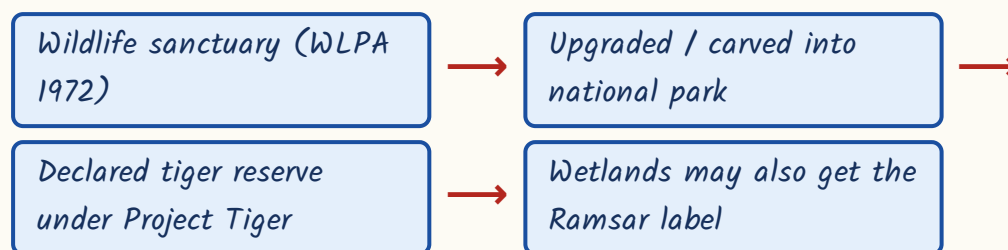
Start here - the legal ladder of protection

Before any table, get the categories straight. All protection in India runs on the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972. That Act gives four kinds of protected area - national park, wildlife sanctuary, conservation reserve and community reserve.

The last two were added by the 2002 amendment, which is why every conservation reserve in Rajasthan is from 2008 onwards.

A tiger reserve is not a fifth category. It is a management layer placed on top of existing parks and sanctuaries under Project Tiger, launched in 1973, and administered by the NTCA. That is why Ranthambore is a national park AND a tiger reserve at the same time, and why Kailadevi and Sawai Man Singh sanctuaries sit inside the Ranthambore Tiger Reserve as buffer. A Ramsar site is different again - it is an international wetland label under the Ramsar Convention of 1971, not an Indian legal category.

How the layers stack in Rajasthan



National park vs wildlife sanctuary - the difference RPSC tests indirectly

National park	Wildlife sanctuary
Highest degree of protection	Slightly lower degree of protection
No grazing or human rights allowed	Certain rights may be permitted
Boundary altered only by state legislature resolution	Easier to alter
Rajasthan has five	Rajasthan has roughly two dozen

TRAP

Do not memorise a single number for sanctuaries and conservation reserves. Sources differ (about 25-27 sanctuaries, and conservation reserves keep being added) because notifications keep coming. The numbers that are fixed and asked are: national parks 5, notified tiger reserves 5, Ramsar sites 5.

The five national parks - learn the district before anything else

Five national parks, and every one of them has a district that gets asked directly. Two of them - Ranthambore and Sariska - are also tiger reserves. One, Keoladeo, is a wetland with no big cat at all. Desert National Park is the giant by area; Keoladeo is the pocket-sized one.

National parks of Rajasthan

National park	District(s)	Known for
Ranthambore	Sawai Madhopur	Tiger; Padam Talab, Raj Bagh, Jogi Mahal, Trinetra Ganesh temple
Keoladeo Ghana	Bharatpur	Birds; smallest NP (28.73 sq km); UNESCO site
Sariska	Alwar	Tiger; site of the world's first tiger relocation
Desert National Park	Jaisalmer and Barmer	Largest NP, about 3,162 sq km; Great Indian Bustard
Mukundra Hills	Kota, Bundi, Jhalawar, Chittorgarh	Carved out of Darrah, Jawahar Sagar and Chambal sanctuaries

- Largest national park - Desert National Park, about 3,162 sq km.
- Smallest national park - Keoladeo Ghana, 28.73 sq km.
- Ranthambore was one of the nine original Project Tiger reserves of 1973; national park in 1980.
- Sariska - tiger reserve 1978, national park 1982.
- Desert NP is the principal surviving refuge of the godawan.
- Kumbhalgarh is a sanctuary and a proposed tiger reserve - NOT a national park; Sitamata is a sanctuary, not a tiger reserve.

Keoladeo Ghana - the most asked single site in this chapter

Keoladeo was a duck-shooting preserve of the Bharatpur rulers. It grew around the Ajan Bandh, built by Maharaja Suraj Mal, and is fed by the Gambhir and Banganga rivers. Learn its four dates in order, because they are asked as an ordering question: bird sanctuary 1956, Ramsar site 1981, national park 1982, UNESCO World Heritage Site 1985. The Siberian crane, its old star visitor, was last recorded there in 2002.

RPSC's favourite negative framing in this section is 'which of the following is NOT a national park' or 'NOT a tiger reserve'. The stock wrong options are Kumbhalgarh and Sitamata. Both are sanctuaries.

Tiger reserves – the notification years ARE the question

Rajasthan has five notified tiger reserves as of September 2026. A sixth, Kumbhalgarh-Todgarh Raoli, has only in-principle approval. Say that carefully in the exam – papers have been set on both the count and on which one is newest, and the state is often reported loosely in the press as 'getting its sixth reserve'.

Tiger reserves of Rajasthan with notification years

Tiger reserve	District(s)	Notified
Ranthambore	Sawai Madhopur	1973 – one of the original nine Project Tiger reserves
Sariska	Alwar	1978
Mukundra Hills	Kota, Bundi, Jhalawar, Chittorgarh	2013
Ramgarh Vishdhari	Bundi	2022
Dholpur-Karauli	Dholpur and Karauli	2023 – India's 54th, Rajasthan's newest
Kumbhalgarh-Todgarh Raoli	Rajsamand, Udaipur, Pali, Ajmer, Sirohi	In-principle approval August 2023; proposed sixth, not yet notified (as of Sept 2026)

Chronology - this exact order was asked as an ordering question



YAAD RAKHO

Yaad rakho the years as a story: 73-78 (the Indira era), then a 35-year gap, then 13-22-23 in a rush. Two in the 1970s, three since 2013. Ramgarh Vishdhari sits in Bundi - remember 'Vishdhari is in Bundi, and the Mej river runs through it'.

Sariska is the reserve with a story attached, and the story is examinable.

Sariska lost all its tigers by 2004-05. In June 2008 tiger ST-1 was airlifted from Ranthambore to Sariska - the world's first relocation of a wild tiger by air. Kailash Sankhala of Jodhpur, the 'Tiger Man of India', was the first director of Project Tiger in 1973; Fateh Singh Rathore is the name associated with Ranthambore.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - which is the fifth and newest notified tiger reserve of Rajasthan? Answer: Dholpur-Karauli, notified 2023, India's 54th tiger reserve. RAS Pre 2023 asked the same table in statement form - five notified reserves, Ramgarh Vishdhari in Bundi, Mukundra Hills 2013, all correct.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: Kumbhalgarh still awaits final notification. NTCA cleared it in principle in August 2023 and the Union environment ministry followed, but the state has to submit the core-buffer and eco-sensitive zone proposal first. Until that notification appears, the correct exam answer to 'how many tiger reserves' remains FIVE.

Sanctuaries matched to districts - the single biggest table in the chapter

This is where the marks are. RPSC asked sanctuary-to-district matching in 2016, 2021, 2023 and 2024. Do not try to learn areas or notification years for all of them - learn district, and for the famous ones, the animal. Read the table twice a week till December.

Sanctuary to district - part I

Wildlife sanctuary	District(s)	Note
Tal Chhapar	Churu	Flat saline grassland; blackbuck, wintering harriers
Sitamata	Pratapgarh (extends to Chittorgarh, Udaipur)	Flying squirrel, chausingha
Kumbhalgarh	Rajsamand, Udaipur, Pali	Indian wolf; proposed tiger reserve
Mount Abu	Sirohi	1960; only sub-tropical evergreen patches of the state
National Chambal	Kota, Bundi, Sawai Madhopur, Dholpur, Karauli	1979; gharial, dolphin, skimmer
Todgarh-Raoli	Ajmer, Pali, Rajsamand	Aravalli sanctuary; part of the Kumbhalgarh proposal

Wildlife sanctuary	District(s)	Note
Jawahar Sagar	Kota, Bundi, Chittorgarh	On the Chambal; feeds Mukundra Hills
Darrah (Rajiv Gandhi)	Kota	Merged into the Mukundra Hills landscape
Sajjangarh	Udaipur	Smallest sanctuary of Rajasthan; around the Monsoon Palace
Phulwari ki Naal	Udaipur	Dense southern Aravalli forest
Jaisamand	Udaipur	Around the Jaisamand lake
Bassi	Chittorgarh	Also has a conservation reserve of the same name
Bhainsrodgarh	Chittorgarh	On the Chambal gorge
Shergarh	Baran	1983; on the Parvan river

Sanctuary to district - part 2

Wildlife sanctuary	District(s)	Note
Kailadevi	Karauli (extends to Sawai Madhopur)	1983; buffer of Ranthambore Tiger Reserve
Sawai Man Singh	Sawai Madhopur	Buffer of Ranthambore Tiger Reserve
Ramgarh Vishdhari	Bundi	Now the core of the 2022 tiger reserve
Bandh Baretha	Bharatpur	Wetland-linked bird habitat
Kesarbagh	Dholpur	Chinkara country
Van Vihar	Dholpur	Old shooting preserve of the Dholpur rulers
Ram Sagar	Dholpur	Waterbirds
Gajner	Bikaner	Imperial sandgrouse, blackbuck; around Gajner lake and palace
Dhawa (Doli)	Jodhpur	Blackbuck and chinkara
Jamwa Ramgarh	Jaipur	Around the old Ramgarh lake

Wildlife sanctuary	District(s)	Note
Nahargarh	Jaipur	Biological park attached
Jhalana	Jaipur	India's first leopard reserve, 2017
Sariska-A	Alwar	Extension block of the Sariska landscape

- Sanctuaries spread over three districts - Kumbhalgarh, Todgarh-Raoli, Jawahar Sagar, Sitamata.
- Dholpur alone holds three sanctuaries - Kesarbagh, Van Vihar and Ram Sagar.
- Kailadevi and Sawai Man Singh are the two sanctuaries inside the Ranthambore Tiger Reserve.
- Smallest sanctuary of the state - Sajjangarh, Udaipur.

TRAP

Two traps in one. First: Todgarh-Raoli is Ajmer-Pali-Rajsamand, NOT Bharatpur - this exact wrong pair has been printed. Second: after the December 2024 reorganisation Rajasthan is back to 41 districts and 7 divisions, so some books show older or newer district names. Khichan is now placed in Phalodi district. For a sanctuary, answer with the classical district (Udaipur, Jodhpur, Barmer) unless the option list clearly uses new districts.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2016 and again in 2024 as a match - Bandh Baretha = Bharatpur, Kesarbagh = Dholpur, Sajjangarh = Udaipur, Sawai Man Singh = Sawai Madhopur. In RAS Pre 2024 the set was Bassi = Chittorgarh, Phulwari ki Naal = Udaipur, Jamwa Ramgarh = Jaipur, Gajner = Bikaner.

Sanctuary to famous species - the second matching set

The other way RPSC frames the same table is species-to-place. Each of these pairs is fixed and none of them overlaps, which is exactly why they make clean options. One warning before you start: godawan is never matched with Keoladeo. Keoladeo is a wetland bird park in Bharatpur; the bustard is a dry-grassland bird of Jaisalmer. 'Great Indian Bustard - Keoladeo' is a standard planted distractor.

Species to protected area

Species	Where you say
Blackbuck	Tal Chhapar (Churu); also Dhawa-Doli, Gajner
Indian giant flying squirrel (uran gilheri)	Sitamata (Pratapgarh)
Chausingha (four-horned antelope)	Sitamata; also Kumbhalgarh
Gharial, Gangetic dolphin, Indian skimmer	National Chambal Sanctuary
Indian wolf	Kumbhalgarh
Leopard	Jhalana and Amargarh (Jaipur), Jawai Bandh (Pali)
Great Indian Bustard (godawan)	Desert National Park (Jaisalmer, Barmer)
Lesser florican (kharmor)	Sorsan (Baran), Shokaliya (Ajmer)
Demoiselle crane (kurja)	Khichan (Phalodi)
Migratory vultures	Jodbeed Gadhwal (Bikaner)
Imperial sandgrouse	Gajner (Bikaner)
Flamingo and other waterbirds	Sambhar Lake in a good monsoon year

YAAD RAKHO

Trick for the four southern sanctuaries: Si-Ku-Ph-Sa - Sitamata (squirrel), Kumbhalgarh (wolf), Phulwari ki Naal (forest), Sajjanganarh (smallest). All four sit in the southern Aravalli belt around Udaipur.

Conservation reserves - newer, smaller, and heavily asked

Conservation reserves were made possible only by the 2002 amendment to the Wildlife Act. They cover land that is often community-owned or revenue land next to an existing protected area. Rajasthan's first three came in 2008, and the state has kept adding them - so the count moves, but the individual name-to-district pairs do not.

Conservation reserve to district

Conservation reserve	District(s)	Note
Bisalpur	Tonk	2008 - first conservation reserve of Rajasthan
Jodbeed Gadhwala	Bikaner	2008 - migratory vultures, including Eurasian griffon
Sundha Mata	Jalore and Sirohi	2008
Jawai Bandh	Pali	2013 - leopard, granite hills
Gudha Vishnoi	Jodhpur	Bishnoi-protected blackbuck country
Rotu	Nagaur	Khejri woodland
Gogelav	Nagaur	Grassland and blackbuck
Beed Jhunjhunu	Jhunjhunu	Old grazing beed
Mansa Mata	Jhunjhunu	Aravalli hill forest
Shakambhari	Sikar and Jhunjhunu	Northern Aravalli
Ummedganj Pakshi Vihar	Kota	Wetland birds
Baghdarrah (Waghdar) crocodile	Udaipur	Mugger crocodile
Sorsan	Baran	Lesser florican grassland
Shahbad	Baran	Dry deciduous forest

- Bassi and Hamirgarh conservation reserves - Chittorgarh and Bhilwara respectively.
- Kharmor Conservation Reserve is in Ajmer, named after the lesser florican.
- Khichan Conservation Reserve, Phalodi - the demoiselle crane village, now also a Ramsar site.
- First conservation reserve = Bisalpur (Tonk, 2008). Remember it with Bisalpur dam, Tonk.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 as a match - Jawai Bandh leopard reserve = Pali, Gudha Vishnoi = Jodhpur, Rotu = Nagaur, Ummedganj = Kota. Learn these four as a block; they have already earned their mark once.

TRAP

Beed Jhunjhunu is in Jhunjhunu, not Barmer - the fake pair 'Beed Jhunjhunu - Barmer' has appeared. Also keep Bassi sanctuary (Chittorgarh) apart from Bassi conservation reserve, and Sorsan conservation reserve (Baran) apart from Shokaliya grassland (Ajmer).

Species conservation - godawan, chinkara, leopard, gharial, cranes

Now the species side. Four or five programmes matter, and each has one number or one place attached to it. Learn the attachment, not the biology.

Great Indian Bustard - godawan

- Adopted as Rajasthan's state bird in 1981; local name godawan.
- Project Great Indian Bustard was launched by the state on 5 June 2013 - World Environment Day.

- Conservation breeding centres are at Sam-Sudasari and Ramdevra, both in Jaisalmer.
- Main wild habitat - Desert National Park; overhead power lines are its chief threat.
- Do not confuse the godawan with the kharmor (lesser florican) of Sorsan and Shokaliya.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: the captive population raised at the Sudasari and Ramdevra centres in Jaisalmer crossed 80 birds by April 2026, built up through egg collection, natural breeding and artificial insemination. This is the best-publicised conservation success story in the state and is prime current-affairs material for December 2026.

- Big cats - Jhalana, Jaipur (2017) is India's first leopard reserve.
- Amargarh, also in Jaipur - Rajasthan's second leopard reserve.
- Jawai Bandh (Pali) - a conservation reserve famous for leopard density among granite hills.
- Tiger: Sariska received relocated tigers from Ranthambore from June 2008 onwards.
- Chinkara (Indian gazelle) - state animal, wild category, 1981; camel is the domestic-category state animal, 2014.

River, wetland and grassland species

- Gharial - National Chambal Sanctuary, 1979; the Chambal is India's best gharial river.
- Demoiselle cranes (kurja) winter at Khichan in Phalodi, fed by the local Jain community.
- Menar in Udaipur is the community-conserved 'bird village' of Rajasthan.

- Flamingos and other waterbirds appear at Sambhar, India's largest inland saline lake.
- Vultures congregate at Jodbeed Gadhwa near Bikaner's carcass dumping ground.

Ramsar sites – five, and three of them are brand new

For thirty-five years Rajasthan had only two Ramsar sites. Then 2025 added three at once. This is the highest-probability current-affairs fact in the whole chapter, so learn all five with their years and districts.

Ramsar sites of Rajasthan

Ramsar site	District	Designated
Keoladeo Ghana	Bharatpur	1981
Sambhar Lake	Jaipur, Nagaur, Ajmer	1990
Khichan	Phalodi	5 June 2025
Menar	Udaipur	5 June 2025
Siliserh Lake	Alwar	2025

- Ramsar Convention on Wetlands, 1971, signed at Ramsar in Iran.
- Keoladeo is both a Ramsar site (1981) and a UNESCO World Heritage Site (1985).
- Pushkar Lake is NOT a Ramsar site – a standard distractor.
- Khichan is famous for demoiselle cranes; Menar is the community-run bird village.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2016 - Sambhar Lake was designated a Ramsar site in 1990. Asked again in RAS Pre 2023 in count form - as of now Rajasthan has FIVE Ramsar sites. Both questions come from the same five-row table.

State symbols, people, institutions - the easy marks

Small section, quick marks. State symbols are asked as a straight one-liner or as a three-statement set. The people and institutions block is the Rajasthan-flavour part that separates a prepared candidate from a general reader.

State symbols of Rajasthan

Symbol	Name	Since
State bird	Godawan / Great Indian Bustard	1981
State animal (wild)	Chinkara	1981
State animal (domestic)	Camel	2014
State tree	Khejri (<i>Prosopis cineraria</i>)	-
State flower	Rohida (<i>Tecomella undulata</i>)	-

- Khejri is called the kalpavriksha of the desert; rohida is the 'Marwar teak' or desert teak.
- The Camel Act (prohibition of slaughter and regulation of export) followed in 2015.
- Khejarli, Jodhpur, 1730 - Amrita Devi Bishnoi and 362 Bishnois died defending khejri trees.
- The Amrita Devi Bishnoi Award is Rajasthan's highest wildlife honour.
- Kailash Sankhala of Jodhpur - 'Tiger Man of India', first director of Project Tiger.

- Biological parks - Nahargarh (Jaipur), Sajjangarh (Udaipur), Machia (Jodhpur), Abheda (Kota).
- Jaipur Zoo, 1876, is the oldest zoo of the state.
- Akal Wood Fossil Park near Jaisalmer - 180-million-year-old Jurassic fossilised tree trunks.
- Wildlife Week is observed from 2 to 8 October every year.
- The Rajasthan State Biodiversity Board works under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002, with Biodiversity Management Committees at panchayat level.

REVISION RECAP

1. Five national parks: Ranthambore (Sawai Madhopur), Keoladeo (Bharatpur), Sariska (Alwar), Desert (Jaisalmer-Barmer), Mukundra Hills (Kota belt).
2. Desert NP largest, about 3,162 sq km; Keoladeo smallest, 28.73 sq km.
3. Keoladeo dates in order - 1956 sanctuary, 1981 Ramsar, 1982 national park, 1985 UNESCO.
4. Ajan Bandh by Maharaja Suraj Mal; Gambhir and Banganga feed Keoladeo; Siberian crane last seen 2002.
5. Tiger reserves and years: Ranthambore 1973, Sariska 1978, Mukundra Hills 2013, Ramgarh Vishdhar 2022, Dholpur-Karauli 2023.
6. Dholpur-Karauli is India's 54th tiger reserve; Kumbhalgarh has only in-principle approval as the proposed sixth (September 2026).
7. World's first tiger airlift relocation - Ranthambore to Sariska, June 2008, tiger ST-1.
8. Tal Chhapar = Churu = blackbuck; Sitamata = Pratapgarh = flying squirrel; Mount Abu = Sirohi; Shergarh = Baran.
9. Kumbhalgarh sanctuary spans Rajsamand-Udaipur-Pali and is known for the Indian wolf.
10. Todgarh-Raoli = Ajmer, Pali, Rajsamand. Never Bharatpur.
11. Dholpur has three sanctuaries - Kesarbagh, Van Vihar, Ram Sagar; Sajjangarh (Udaipur) is the smallest.
12. Kailadevi (Karauli) and Sawai Man Singh (Sawai Madhopur) form the Ranthambore buffer.
13. First conservation reserve - Bisalpur, Tonk, 2008; Jodbeed Gadhwal (Bikaner) for vultures.

14. Jawai Bandh (Pali) leopard, Gudha Vishnoi (Jodhpur), Rotu and Gogelav (Nagaur), Ummedganj (Kota).
15. Five Ramsar sites - Keoladeo 1981, Sambhar 1990, Khichan and Menar June 2025, Siliserh (Alwar) 2025.
16. State symbols - godawan 1981, chinkara 1981, camel 2014, khejri, rohida.
17. Project GIB launched 5 June 2013; breeding centres Sam-Sudasari and Ramdevra, Jaisalmer.
18. Jhalana (Jaipur, 2017) India's first leopard reserve; Amargarh the second.
19. Khejarli 1730 - Amrita Devi Bishnoi, 362 martyrs; the state's top wildlife award carries her name.
20. Kailash Sankhala - Tiger Man of India, first Project Tiger director; Wildlife Week 2-8 October; Jaipur Zoo 1876.